

Perennialism

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Introduction

Perennialism is a reaction against progressivism, which it believes is destroying the intellectual fabric of American life by its emphasis in the schools on student-centeredness, presentism, and life adjustment (Knight, 1982). It agrees with progressive education practices but faults it for lacking educational ends. The roots of Perennialism lie in the philosophy of Plato, Aristotle, and St. Thomas Aquinas. The philosophic belief is divided into two groups: those who espouse the religious approach to education adopted by St. Thomas Aquinas, and those who follow the secular approach formulated in twentieth-century America by Robert Hutchins and Mortimer Adler. Both Robert Hutchins and Mortimer Adler are traditionalists who have led the perennial ideals at the University of Chicago since 1929 (Knight, 1982). The perennialists advocate the time-honored ideas of human culture and those that have proven their validity and usefulness by withstanding the test of time. In this paper, I will focus on the secular approach of perennialism, which, philosophically, strives above all to develop our capacity to reason and regards training in the humanities as particularly essential to the development of our rational powers. I am also taking a leap into perennial ideals of the past and trying to shape the present.

Educational Philosophy

Perennialism is an educational philosophy based on Neo-Scholasticism and relies heavily on Aristotle's thoughts. The philosophy emphasizes the importance of the mind, reason, and the great works of the intellectual past. It is also an educational philosophy that is protesting the concept of liberal education. Liberal education in the classical tradition has centered on studies that make people free and truly human, rather than on the training people receive to perform specific tasks in the world of work (Knight, 1928). Perennialists urge schools to spend more time teaching concepts and explaining their meaning to students. It suggests that greater emphasis be placed on teacher-guided seminars, where students and teachers engage in Socratic dialogues or mutual inquiry sessions to develop a deeper understanding of history's most timeless concepts. In addition, perennialists recommend that students learn directly from reading and analyzing Great Books. These are the creative works by history's finest thinkers and writers, which perennialists believe are as profound, beautiful, and meaningful today as when they were written.

There are two types of learning: learning to become a worker and learning to become a thinker. A worker focuses on acquiring skills that rely on physical strength and muscle, while a

thinker is trained to develop intellectual abilities. Additionally, there are two types of education: liberal education and education for work.

Perennialists argue that both thinkers and workers need a liberal education to think critically and communicate effectively, rather than being trained solely for physical labor through vocational education. In today's world, education is often seen as a means to function within an orderly society, where both workers and thinkers play crucial roles in maintaining these systems. Consequently, educational training is increasingly focused on preparing individuals to perform specific tasks.

So, can we truly differentiate between the worker and the thinker? The answer is no. If a thinker invents machinery but cannot operate it, we end up with a broken system. In my field of engineering, we have role-based systems that include architects, designers, technicians, packagers, and quality assurance professionals. All these roles are filled by experts in their respective fields, each with some level of college education.

While perennialists advocate for general education rather than specialization, the reality is that survival in today's society often requires specialization in a particular field, such as medicine or engineering (including computer, electrical, chemical, or mechanical disciplines). All roles are equally important and can be viewed as both worker and thinker.

Common knowledge for these professionals includes interoffice communication, interpersonal development, and the operation of general office equipment. Mortimer Adler stated, "The Paideia Program seeks to establish a course of study that is general, not specialized; liberal, not vocational; humanistic, not technical. Only in this way can it fulfill the meaning of the words 'paideia' and 'humanities,' which signify the general learning that should be in the possession of every human being."

Adler emphasizes that, in addition to expertise in a specific field, individuals need a well-rounded education that encompasses aspects of humanity. Ohlone's general education (GE) program exemplifies this idea, offering courses in art, literature, and history. Perennialists largely focus on improving secondary education, particularly at the college level. Meanwhile, the role of elementary education is to equip students with the tools necessary to study and understand the liberal tradition in the future.

Perennialism is a philosophical orientation that emphasizes the ideas contained in the Great Books and maintains that the true purpose of education is the discovery of the universal, or perennial, truths of life. I feel that learning about art and literature, such as reading a great novel, seeing a dance show, and looking at paintings, will help broaden your perspective. When you have a good background in culture and literature, it can help out in many ways. It is not just about reading Shakespeare, but about reading a lesson from the past. The plays Shakespeare

wrote give you a little history of the time period. Also, it teaches you to have an imagination. It does not matter what your major is; what is important is broadening your imagination. At the same time, it helps you grow. That is to say, if you can imagine what you can become, then you can achieve it.

Robert Hutchins and Mortimer Adler are two of the most influential figures among perennialists for their editing of the massive collection titled “Great Books of the Western World” (Knight, 1982). These collections contain the best in ideas and thoughts of the intellectual past. The great books of ancient, medieval, and modern times are a repository of knowledge and wisdom, a cultural tradition that must be initiated by each generation. And according to Robert Hutchins, textbooks have probably done as much to degrade American intelligence as any single force.

Early perennialism was traditional, classical education in a revived form, with a more specific theoretical formulation. In the thirteenth century, St. Thomas Aquinas, an Italian, espoused the religious approach to education and has shaped the nature of Catholic schools throughout the world. Like the secular approach of perennialism, it holds that universal truths and values exist and that all people should receive the same education. In addition, it stresses that a supreme being, a knowing and loving God, created the universe and human beings within it (Gutek, 1988). The beliefs: all religions say the same thing. Given the manifold expressions of religious impulse throughout history, many find this hard to believe. Do all religions talk about God? What about Buddhism? Do all religions preach individual salvation? Do all religions teach reincarnation? What about Christianity? It is obvious that on the level of content, the perennialist claim is difficult to defend. In world history, we have had two major world wars, and in some way, they have to do with conflict of beliefs. Who is to say that is not related to religious beliefs? What is important for us as a society is understanding religious differences, and people should learn to respect them and their beliefs. Hopefully, the lesson of the past is a living example and will not be repeated.

Purpose of Education

- Permanence is of a greater reality than change
- The universe is orderly and patterned
- The basic features of human nature reappear in each generation regardless of time or place
- Human nature is universal in its essential characteristics
- Like human nature, the basic goals of education are universal and timeless
- The human being’s defining characteristic is rationality, which is education’s task to cultivate
- The fund of wisdom of the human race is recorded in certain classic works

Curriculum

- Acquiring organized knowledge
- Developing learning and intellectual skills
- Enlarging the understanding of ideas and values

Learn Best

- Begin with subject matter, not student
- Correct and critical thinking
- Teacher as example of values and ideas
- Emphasize rational thinking
- “Sage on the stage, not guide on the side”

Knowledge

- Great ideas from scholars, poets
- Great principles (as opposed to specific content)
- “Truth”
- Rational thinking processes

Conclusion

As the name suggests, "perennial" means "everlasting" and implies that people should have a common knowledge of our world, understand the great works of history, and learn to live/work with each other in harmony. Perennialism espouses the notion that the great works of the intellectual past are as relevant today as when they were first conceived. It advocates making these ideas the focus of education. According to perennialists, when students are immersed in the study of profound, enduring ideas, they will appreciate learning for its own sake and become true intellectuals. In other words, it stresses the importance of mind, reason, and the proven methodology of the great works of the intellectual past. For my personal philosophy of education, I would like a combination of approaches of Perennialism, Progressivism, and Pragmatism.

Theorists

- Mortimer Adler (Paideia Proposal)
- Robert Hutchin (Great Books Program)
- Augustine
- Plato
- Aristotle
- St. Thomas Aquinas

References

Gutek, G. L. (1988) *Philosophical and Ideological Perspectives on Education*, Englewood Cliffs, New Jersey: Prentice Hall.

Knight, G.R. (1982) *Issues and Alternatives in Educational Philosophy*, Berrien Springs, Michigan: Andrew University Press.